

NYU News

Shared E-Scooters Have Benefited New York and Washington D.C. Without Adding Traffic or Safety Woes, But They Lag in Low-Income Neighborhoods

An analysis of Lime-gathered survey data by NYU transportation research center sees need for new pricing and deployment strategies by private operators

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In New York City, Washington, D.C., and Paris, shared e-scooters do not appear to add to the net number of vehicles of all types on the road, according to [a new report](#) by New York University transportation researchers. In Lime’s survey data on average annual data traffic, 16-23% of riders in the three cities reported that they substituted a motor vehicle trip with a scooter ride, the report finds.

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transportation systems when paired with thoughtful policy, the analysis today from Sarah Kaufman, assistant clinical professor at the university’s Rudin Center for Transportation Policy, and a graduate research assistant at the center and the report’s

operator’s survey data – titled “Micromobility, Macro Utility: Benefits in NYC, D.C., and Paris” – was sponsored by the Lime

Among findings of the 48-page report:

- Pricing and deployment strategies are necessary to reach low-income communities and ensure equitable use of e-scooter.
- E-scooters play a significant role in first-and last-mile access to public transit, often beginning or ending near subway stations. In the Bronx, for example, 41% of Lime trips occurred within a quarter-mile of a subway station, thereby “extending transit’s reach.”
- Safety outcomes are comparable to bicycling, with internal data from Lime indicating incident rates well below 0.01% of trips across all cities study (the New York City portion of the study looks at two boroughs – Queens and the Bronx.)
- Safety incidents are more prominent in personally owned, not shared, e-scooters.

E-scooters began appearing in U.S. cities in 2017. Lime is among three private e-scooter operators in New York City, with the others being Bird and Veo.

“Cities, operators, and e-scooter users benefit from shared scooter fleets as a low-emissions commuting alternative that can enhance public transit systems through first-and-last-mile connections,” writes Bruursema. “However, cities must be strategic in permitting fleet deployments in order to ensure that scooters increase mobility options for residents, while not simultaneously causing excess safety or quality of life concerns.

“Additionally, cities can consider the parameters of permitting (with regard to both geography and pricing for the service) if they want to ensure scooters are accessible to residents of all income brackets.”

“Perception of safety, however, remains a significant factor,” Bruursema adds. “Media narratives and public concern often exceed measured risk levels, highlighting the importance of infrastructure design, enforcement, and public engagement.”

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